

Change in Control

John Hoogland

Pallas Athena

Piet Joubertstraat 4, 7315 AV Apeldoorn, The Netherlands

johnhoogland@pallas-athena.com

Outline

Change is a popular word since Barack Obama so successfully used it in his campaign to become president of the US. Change almost became a synonym for “yes, we can”. Change, and things will improve. Suddenly change is sexy. We don’t seem to suffer from resistance to change anymore. People now LIKE to change?

Control usually is considered to almost be opposite to change. Control is not sexy. It is associated with accountants, budget restrictions, penalties, rules. It is considered to be counterproductive. You need it for compliance, but how easy would it be to change without control?

BPM is stuck in the middle. It used to be positioned as a technology that improves efficiency, effectiveness and quality. Cheaper, faster and better. But suddenly BPM is all about Agility. BPM for change. BPM is sexy too! At the same time, BPM is considered to be a tool for compliance, risk management and a means to guarantee SLA’s, KPI’s, etc. Control!

So how can this be? BPM does not bring agility by itself. Nothing is more agile than processes that are not under control of any system. BPM is only called agile, because it gives more flexibility than built-in process control in legacy applications. At least, that is what we all believe (or say we believe). We call this the flexibility paradox. Process automation adds control, takes away flexibility and at the same time brings agility.

What do analysts, vendors and consultants say about BPM and agility?

Gartner says: “Business Process Management is a discipline that enables business agility in three important ways. It allows faster and better-informed decisions, reduces the process revision cycle time, and promotes consensus for rapid adoption of change”[1].

It is very important to realize that two different types of agility are mixed here. First of all, there is the ability to make better change decisions based on better data and communicated in a better way. Second, there is the ability to execute changes easier and faster. In this position paper, the emphasis is on the second form of agility.

Most vendors of BPM suites connect the concept of agility to two BPM functionalities:

1. Round trip BPM, meaning that the iterative process cycle from design to execution, reporting and analysis is done in one integrated environment, allowing business users to be heavily involved.

2. Rules engines, allowing to change business rules without the need to change the process definition.

It is really surprising to see that hardly any vendor or analyst explains HOW a BPM system delivers better agility. It is almost considered to be common sense, like you don't have to explain why you get warm in the sun. But it is not that obvious at all. So how can agility be achieved through executing and controlling business processes by automating them?

Flexibility in business processes can be achieved in two ways:

1. Intrinsic flexibility thanks to a rich BPM engine able to support many workflow patterns, resource patterns or even exception handling patterns [2,3,4]
2. Flexibility through adaptability of process behavior.

The main difference between the two is that in the first case any change in the behavior of the system needs a change in the process definition. That is why better engines offer more flexibility. The goal is to prevent changes in the definition of processes, because however easy it is to make these changes, every change will require releasing a new version of the process model. And such a version upgrade will need to be tested, accepted and therefore planned. This is especially true when the process is highly integrated with other applications or services in the infrastructure. Based on experience, one might state that these changes cannot be effectuated more than three times per year. This process cycle is often called the *outer circle* of process management.

Therefore, support for many patterns, operational flexibility that allows end users to defer from the process definition in a controlled way (based on seniority for instance), exception handling capabilities like skipping steps, roll back processes with compensation actions, ad-hoc activities, etc. etc., all bring about functionality that prevent releasing new versions. This concept is implemented in a number of BPM tools, but hardly communicated as such. Many vendors even with these capabilities in their product, still market agility in relation to easier modeling, round trip modeling (from process design to execution without intermediate translation). And this is strange, since round trip modeling is not a differentiator, while the mentioned capabilities are!

In the second case, which can be referred to as the *inner circle*, changes in the behavior of the BPM system can be achieved through parameterization in rules, distribution, process variables, resource allocation, web services, etc. The goal is that in a separated configuration environment, business users are able to adapt the process, without the need to release a new version. The cycle time of these kind of changes is short (often real-time), and preferably the configuration capabilities are decentralized in business domains, and hierarchical layers, ensuring in this way that business managers can only make changes in business areas for which they are responsible or authorized. Inner circle support brings true agility. Work distribution can be changed ad hoc and real time, without any IT support. Business rules can be adapted without the need to release new versions. Process thresholds for control steps, escalation steps, can be lowered or increased in order to cope with unexpected workload, deadlines and SLA's can temporarily be adapted for the same reason.

And this is how we find the equilibrium between change and control. The outer circle brings control where needed, the inner circle offers the flexibility to manoeuvre between clear boundaries. Change in control.

References

1. Hill, J., Melenovsky, M.: Achieving Agility: BPM Delivers Business Agility through New Management Practices; Gartner. Gartner Report G00137553 (2006)
2. Russell, N., Ter Hofstede, A., van der Aalst, W., Mulyar, N.: Workflow control-flow patterns: A revised view. BPM Center Report BPM-06-22, BPMcenter. org, 06-22 (2006)
3. Russell, N., Hofstede, A., Edmond, D., Aalst, W.: Workflow Resource Patterns. BETA Working Paper Series, WP 127, Eindhoven University of Technology, Eindhoven (2005)
4. Russell, N., van der Aalst, W., ter Hofstede, A.: Exception handling patterns in process-aware information systems. BPM Center Report BPM-06-04, BPMcenter. org, 06-04 (2006)